others, and along the way even encounter the occasional Scot from Britain and the Jew from Baghdad.

Parsi Emigration and Efflorescence

The Parsis ‘are probably the smallest community in the whole world, for they number scarcely a hundred thousand’. Thus began D.F. Karaka’s majestic *History of the Parsis* in 1884, documenting the history of a community that would go on to have an outsized influence in shaping modern India. The community gave rise to India’s first articulate economic nationalist, Dadabhai Naoroji (1825–1917), the first cotton mill entrepreneur, C.N. Davar (1814–73), and also the largest business conglomerate of the past century—the Tata Group. It gave rise to women stalwarts such as the pioneering lawyer Cornelia Sorabji (1866–1954) and freedom fighter Bhikaiji Cama (1861–1936) in the early 20th century, at a time when women rarely entered public life. Later, the community’s contributions came in a variety of fields ranging from the armed forces (Sam Manekshaw) to science (Homi Bhabha) to law (Nani Palkhivala) and music (Zubin Mehta). By the end of the 20th century, the Godrej brand became synonymous with locks and steel cupboards. This remarkable Parsi efflorescence over 200 years has a unique migration history, linked in popular memory with sugar and ships and, perhaps not so popularly, with narcotics.

Parsis have bittersweet memories about their origins. They are bitter because they left Persia—hence the word ‘Parsi’—after the collapse of the Sassanid Empire in the 7th century CE due to the persecution of their Zoroastrian faith that was founded in the first millennium BCE.[3] It is sweet because of the legend that on being asked why they [Parsis] should be accommodated in a land filled to the brim, they explained to the local ruler, Jadi Rana, who reigned over a part of present-day Gujarat in the 8th century CE, that they would be like sugar in milk—enhancing but not overwhelming.[4] Impressed, the ruler gave them permission to reside in Sanjan on the west coast, today equidistant between Surat and Mumbai, but